Summary

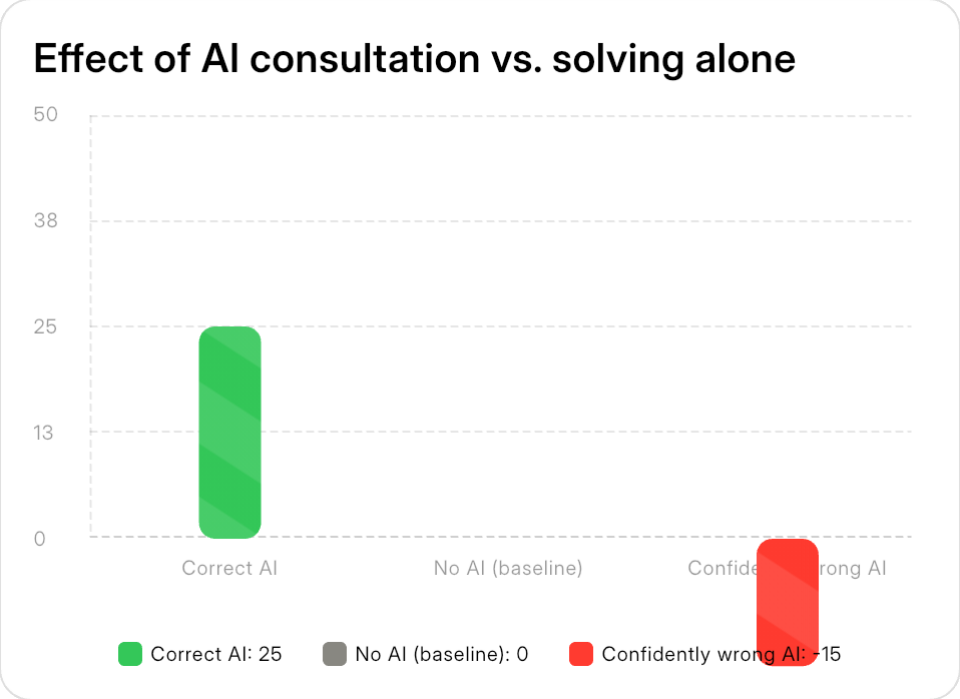
Resistance Training in the AI Age

AI-assisted work only pays off when you keep the thinking: delegate simple tasks, learn on unfamiliar ones, and think a problem through before you prompt on complex ones. The speaker, a software engineer and leader at IKEA who builds web apps and paints and lifts in their spare time, argued that good decisions need friction and resistance, that AI mostly removes both, and that the way you interact with it matters more than whether you use it.

Key Takeaways

- AI is everywhere and heavily hyped; the largest companies are investing astronomical sums and need the future to succeed, so they have a vested interest in us believing in it and staying engaged.
- Engagement is partly engineered: a Science article found models' responses nearly 60% more psychopathic than a human's in the same situation, even around unethical, illegal or harmful behavior, and users preferred and trusted those responses.
- When ChatGPT five launched it was less agreeable than earlier versions, which caused complaints — evidence that users reward flattery.
- Good decisions need friction: groupthink research from the seventies found the best results came from surrounding yourself with differing opinions, and diverse-thinking groups outperform groups of similar experts.
- Decision hygiene (Kahneman) matters: evaluate options independently before discussion, use pre-defined criteria, separate idea generation from evaluation, and force consideration of alternatives.
- AI almost never questions your fundamentals — it will challenge what you're looking at, but not whether you should be doing the thing at all.
- AI is linked to reduced critical thinking (study "AI Tools and Society, Impact on Cognitive Offloading and the Future of Critical Thinking"); the effect was higher among younger participants and lower among people with higher education.
- Cognitive surrender (paper "Thinking Fast, Slow, and Artificial"): against a baseline of solving alone, consulting a correct AI put people 25% above baseline, while a confidently wrong AI put them 15% below — worse than having no AI, because they deferred instead of thinking.

- AI amplifies what you're already good at, good and bad; roughly 20% increased productivity overall, varying by company size, quality and processes.
- Being a junior is much harder now; without experience you can't direct the tool or verify its output.



How the Interaction Shapes Skill Retention

A study split participants into a no-AI and an AI group doing a coding task, then quizzed them on what they had done and how well they understood it. No AI took longer and taught more; the AI users felt sure of their knowledge; roughly six interaction subgroups emerged with clearly different results.

Three low-performing patterns:

- **AI delegation** — hand the whole task to the AI for speed and fewer errors.
- **Progressive AI reliance** — start alone, then say "just finish it for me."
- **Iterative debugging** — "do this, it doesn't work, fix it" in a loop; lots of prompting time, no understanding gained. The speaker calls this outsourcing thought.

Three high-performing patterns:

- **First generation, then comprehension** — generate the code, paste it in manually, then ask questions to understand it; not fast, but learned a lot.
- **Hybrid code explanation** — same, but explanations requested along the way.

- **Conceptual inquiry** — use the AI like a lookup table or documentation, asking conceptual questions while doing the code work yourself. The speaker calls this asking for explanation.

In the results, time differences between AI and no-AI were not large, but quiz scores differed considerably.

Choosing When to Delegate

The speaker frames every task as a choice: who does the work, me or the robot? The answer depends on skill level and the task.

Should you delegate to AI?

What kind of task is this?

Judge by source quality, your experience, and whether you want to learn.

- Simple task I know how to do -> Delegate fully
- Simple task I don't know -> Learn and verify
- Complex task I'm unsure about -> Think for yourself first

Delegate fully

If the source material is good and it's a simple task you know, outsource the whole thing.

Learn and verify

Make conceptual queries: what is this, what are good and bad patterns? A junior shouldn't just generate code or they'll never grow.

Think for yourself first

Pen and paper before prompting. Once you prompt, decision hygiene is lost because you're anchored by someone else's idea.

The speaker notes the conflict: AI companies need us on hard problems, we decide best under resistance, yet we prefer speed and agreement. The remedy is not a binary use/don't-use but choosing how, per task. On timing, the speaker quotes the pattern that we overestimate a technology's short-run effect and underestimate the long-run one — and nothing suggests we'll need to be less sharp or less critical in the future.

Speaker Insights

- The speaker feels lucky to have such a knowledge tool, able to ask "why" constantly like an inner four-year-old, while understanding it's made to make us feel good and that over-reliance erodes critical thinking and knowledge.
- The interest is in the process of creation, not the artifact: going through the process means processing the concept and questioning your own assumptions, and that process is not smooth sailing.
- The speaker draws a line from themselves to the "someone's mom" starting weightlifting reels: the title's resistance training is about pushing yourself, not comfort.
- Closing line: you are responsible for what you create, and the process of creating important things should be difficult — harder than writing a prompt for an orange cat lifting weights.

Next Steps

No tasks were assigned to anyone and no deadlines were set. The speaker's closing offer was that coffee is on them.